

KELLOGG SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT KELLOGG

The Kellogg School of Management is part of Northwestern University, located in Evanston about 12 miles north of downtown Chicago. The beautiful lakeside location in a thriving student town is a big part of the Kellogg culture, with time to cultivate strong ties with classmates that is so much part of the school's close-knit community. The collaborative learning style of the MBA program reinforces these ties, with a heavy emphasis on teamwork - 'we' rather than 'I'.

Stereo-typed as the school for marketing, Kellogg is in fact so much more. The school looks for strong quant skills to underpin sharp analytical skills. So why does McKinsey recruit more Kellogg MBAs than any other U.S. school? Because they have humility, great analytical skills, and the people skills that mean they can be client facing from day one.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Marketing, general management, non-profit/social responsibility, production/operations, strategy, entrepreneurship, healthcare, consumer goods.

KEY STATS

MBA RANKINGS*	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
BusinessWeek	8	8	10	10	*	*	4
Financial Times	12	12	14	11	6	5	9
US News	4	6	6	3	4	4	2
Poets and Quants	5	5	5	5	4	4	4

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants	4,187	Avg GMAT	729
MBA Class Size	503	Avg GPA	3.7
Tuition	\$156,552	Int'l Students	38%
Ave Age	28	Female Students	48%

POST-MBA CAREERS

Consulting	38%
Technology	24%
Financial Services	17%
Consumer Products	8%
Students starting new business	17%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:

McKinsey, Bain, BCG, PwC Strategy&, EY Parthenon, Accenture, Lincoln International, Amazon, Adobe, JP Morgan, Nike, Google, Meta, Visa, Wayfair

AVERAGE BASE SALARY:	US\$159,000
SALARY INCREASE:	122%
EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS:	98%



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR KELLOGG APPLICATION

BY WILLIAM KOTAS

A Kellogg alumnus, Willie's dedication to serving others began with a two-year stint in the Peace Corps. His involvement with Kellogg never paused upon his graduation; he led alumni clubs in Peru, South Florida, and Brazil, was honored as Kellogg's worldwide alumni volunteer of the year in 2011, Willie met individually with hundreds of high potentials considering MBA or EMBA studies, offering them unique insight into what Kellogg and competing top tier programs seek in candidates.



Almost every aspect of the application has some component geared toward understanding if a student is the right cultural fit.

1

PLAY TO YOUR STRENGTHS...EVEN IF THEY SEEM CONVENTIONAL

Kellogg prides itself on building a truly diverse class across lots of dimensions. One of the signature traditions during orientation is for the Dean of Admissions to give a speech called “One of You” that runs down a list of remarkable highlights about new students. Admissions officers take great pride in identifying candidates who have really self-reflecting on what they want and how Kellogg will get them there. The key is to embrace your genuine story even if it seems entirely normal – failing to do so trips up more applicants than you can imagine. If you’ve taken a traditional path in banking because that’s your interest, then own that. After all, an entire class can’t be filled by Peace Corps workers who started their own microfinance funds and sing professionally on the side. And if you try to spice up your application with details or stories that read falsely, officers will sniff them out immediately.

DIFFERENTIATE YOURSELF BASED ON YOUR CONVENTIONS

2

Kellogg has become so diverse that more conventional paths can stand out. This is particularly true if you’re coming from finance with plans to potentially stay in that industry or make a pivot from, say, private equity to investment banking. There is concern in some quarters that the program has embraced the poets at the expense of the quants. While this reflects a shift amongst the applicant pool (and the broader decline of interest in finance as the prestige MBA path), the school is very much attuned to applicants with a linear story and exceptional quant skills.

3

TELL A GOOD STORY

This doesn't mean embellish. Quite the opposite, the advice here is to aim for consistency in putting together your application with clear threads throughout. You definitely want to aim high, but make sure the supporting elements are solid. Do your essays and letters of recommendation define a similar vision? Do your letters of recommendation and interview paint a similar portrait? Do your undergrad experiences line up with your essays? Candidates can sometimes get a little carried away, which leads to big dreams that don't seem based in any previous experiences.

RECOGNIZE THAT CULTURE MATTERS – AND KNOW WHAT THAT MEANS

4

As the Kellogg culture has become more deeply ingrained, the need to preserve it has heightened. Officers feel a real sense of obligation to protect what makes the school unique. Almost every aspect of the application has some component geared toward understanding if a student is the right fit. So what exactly does this culture of collaboration entail? Dean Blount expresses it as impact without ego, and that's about as good a definition as exists. Another way to think about the culture is like this: the program will force you to work in team settings constantly. Most people can be dependable peers for an hour at a time. But what if you're in hour 12 of an intense case analysis? Do you still have the maturity to be just as diplomatic as in hour 1? A strong applicant will show strong situational awareness and examples of how they can work in lots of different types of teams.

5

HAVE A VIABLE ALTERNATIVE

Perhaps the most oft-cited critique or question from a Kellogg officer: “does this person have a plan b?” That’s another way of saying that the story didn’t quite come together and that the ending in particular is concerning. In the high-stakes rankings game, Kellogg has done well in large part with the employment record of a large percentage of its graduates. The careers staff do a phenomenal job in working with students, but they also don’t want to have to take unnecessary risks. To tie this all together with the other tips, if you’re plan is to start your own company but you have no entrepreneurship anywhere in your background and your recommenders say you’re risk-averse, you need to display a viable alternative. And at a school in which competition for a position in consulting is fierce, working for Bain, BCG or McKinsey in order to “round out your experiences and get exposed to lots of different industries” is not a solid backup.

Read Fortuna’s insider guidance for Kellogg’s essays [here](#).

DEADLINES & DATES

	APPLICATION DEADLINE
Round 1	13 September 2023
Round 2	10 January 2024
Round 3	03 April 2024



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, MIT Sloan, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

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